

WHY IT IS A GEM

- **The NGO has helped 100 new homestays come up around Sikkim that are both lucrative and environmentally responsible**
- **It has renewed springs and groundwater sources that villages need for drinking and farming**

Two planks are central to this NGO's work in Sikkim: water and tourism. By combining them adeptly, they have started a virtuous cycle of healthy farm produce, steady passive incomes and lucrative skill-building across local communities. Called the Ecotourism & Conservation Society of Sikkim (ECOSS), it is a grassroots organisation that has been working in one of India's most eco-sensitive regions for more than two decades to nudge locals towards homegrown environment-friendly policies. Founded in January 2001 and based in Gangtok, it is inspired by the simple idea that Sikkim's natural wealth cannot be protected unless local communities steer the conversation.

EXPERTSPEAK

"ECOSS's greatest strength is connecting with local communities by speaking their language and understanding their customs. Locals take ownership of new initiatives"

OMI GURUNG
Environmentalist, also known as The Green Man of Sikkim

Ecofriendly homestays have been a big part of ECOSS's strategy. By studying models across rural Sikkim, documenting their economic and social impact and feeding these findings to the government, the organisation has helped ensure that regulations are grounded in lived experience. "Success has drawn in younger people, many of whom are eager to start homestays of their own. Trekking routes that had fallen silent are vibrant again, offering visitors organic food, clean mountain air and an experience rooted in a living landscape," says Paul Karna Rai, a local homestay owner. "Once a few households saw homestays could actually generate income while preserving local cultures and dignity, the model sold itself," says Prem Das Rai, Founder and Chairman at ECOSS. The NGO has made a five-year ecotourism marketing plan under the Japan International Cooperation Agency project for the state forest department.

Water is the other critical local concern, which extends to the larger Himalayan region. In collaboration with National Bank for Agriculture and Rural Development, ECOSS has implemented a water conservation project in Raigaon village to recharge the source of mountain streams. These interventions involve renewing springs and rejuvenating groundwater sources that villages need for drinking and farming.

Today, ECOSS stands as a rare example of an organisation that has evolved with Sikkim itself: grounded in local realities, trusted by communities and respected by governments and international partners alike. Its story is not one of spectacle, but of steady, thoughtful work, reshaping how development is imagined in the fragile Eastern Himalayas. ■